



Out of Office, Indefinitely

Interviewing Staff on Why an Auto-Reply Outlives the Trip It Announced

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Motivation

An out-of-office auto-reply is switched on for a fixed trip and carries its own end date in the text. Little is known about why the reply keeps firing well after that date, or what staff tell themselves in the meantime.

Research questions

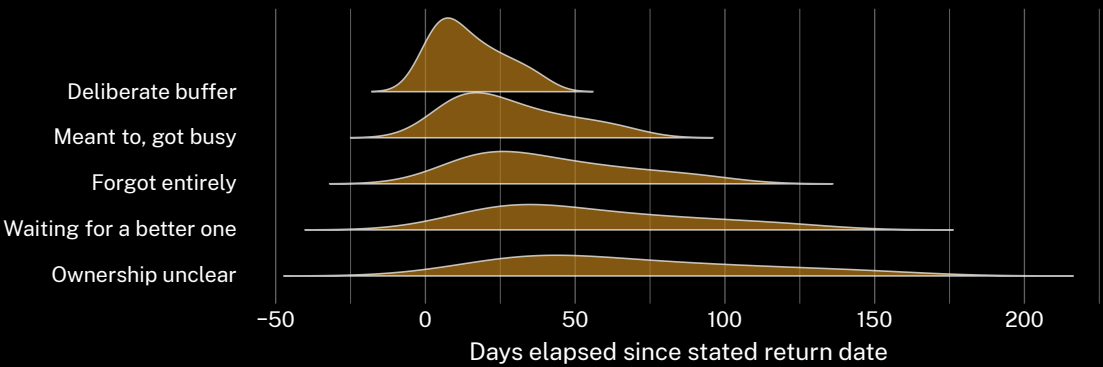
- Whether a reply's stated return date predicts when it is actually disabled.
- What reasons staff give, unprompted, for the gap.
- Whether the reason offered predicts how long the reply has already run, or only how much longer it will.

Study design

- n = 156 staff across nine organisations · semi-structured interview + reply-log audit · interviewed only once a reply had run 3+ days past its stated date.
- Open coding of stated reasons into a five-category taxonomy, two coders, disagreements adjudicated blind to reply-log timestamps.
- Organisation and role held constant against interview order; category assignment logged before the log was consulted.

Findings

Reasons cluster into five categories, and the category a respondent offers predicts how long the reply has already run rather than how much longer it will. Ownership-unclear respondents carry by far the longest overrun; deliberate-buffer respondents the shortest.



Ownership-unclear replies had run a median 61 days past their stated date at interview (IQR 34–104, n = 31), more than triple the deliberate-buffer group's median 17 days (IQR 9–26, n = 44), interviewed March–June 2026.

Implications & where next

A stated return date reads as a commitment but functions as a suggestion the moment nobody owns the inbox. Deliberate-buffer replies resolve fastest precisely because someone decided to leave them, not because anyone circled back sooner. Next: a field trial testing whether a reply that names a named colleague as backup contact shortens the overrun more than one that merely restates the date.

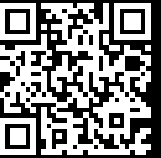
Selected references

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Ethics: exempt low-risk human research approval 2026/114; quotes de-identified before coding.

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“The reply says next Tuesday. Tuesday was February.”

68% of the 156 replies audited were still firing a month past their own stated date (2026).